

DIFFERENT SPORT. SIMILAR SPECTACLE.

The **Esports World Cup** showed that the ingredients of a great sporting spectacle like the World Cup extend beyond the game itself.

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What makes a World Cup? Is it the sport, the inevitable tensions around it, or the fans who, like hopeless romantics, turn up to support their favourite teams and athletes, taking home tokens of vicarious success and joy?

The Esports World Cup, which began during the second half of the 2026 FIFA World Cup, posed a similar question. But on arriving in Paris, the host city for this year's marquee esports tournament, the fog of uncertainty cleared to reveal a few answers.

At the main venue, Paris Expo Porte de Versailles, thousands of youngsters moved from one hall to another. Some hunched over computers, while others played drums and chanted songs in support of their esports teams.

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